

'ANOTHER PLANET'

Prison life is harsh. Time spent in a 'segregation unit' is even worse.

IN 1974, Michael Jackson received a hand-written note he thought strained credulity. Written by a prisoner in the B.C. Penitentiary, which closed in 1980, the letter complained about life in solitary confinement. "It described conditions I doubted existed in Canadian prisons," recalls the University of British Columbia criminal law professor. Still, he visited the letter-writer—and was shocked by the squalid cells, antagonistic guards, and ritual humiliations. He took up the cause and in 1975 the Federal Court of Canada ruled the conditions constituted cruel and unusual punishment and were unlawful.

Since then, Jackson has spent much more time inside prisons. There have been many improvements, he says, but nothing changes the potential for abuse inherent in the relationship between "the keepers and the kept." One example: with "administrative segregation," a warden can keep an individual isolated, essentially at will. Jackson says prisoners say it's like "living on another planet."

The photos here were taken at the segregation units of B.C.'s Kent and Matsqui institutions, by Shane Jackson for his father's critically acclaimed second book, *Justice Behind the Walls*. Clockwise from above right: [1] Jeff Blackburn, on the 30th of 74 days in "the hole." [2] High walls and a wire-mesh ceiling block sun from Kent's exercise yard. [3] Even after a jury acquitted Hughie McDonald of murdering a fellow prisoner, it took a B.C. Supreme Court ruling to spring him from segregation. [4] The same size as a cell, or "house," in the main living unit at Matsqui, a segregation cell is more austere. [5] Kent interview room. [6] Electronic surveillance means towers are now used only in emergencies. But Jackson was later told that when he visited prisons in the '70s, tower guards had their guns trained on his head.

For more photos and the text of the book, visit www.justicebehindthewalls.net. M

